Lesson notes · for you

ETL with Python and SQL

Data engineering · Level 4 · Lesson 2

Time
17 min

Materials
Your phone or a computer, for the Python and SQL steps; Paper, to sketch a pipeline

Learning goals

- Build extract, transform, load.
- Make loads idempotent: delete-then-insert, or upsert.
- Load incrementally and log every run.

Activity: Break the pipeline

1. Draw (4 min): Sketch the school attendance pipeline: sources, transform, district table, schedule.
2. Fail (5 min): For each step, write what's left behind if it fails halfway, and what a plain rerun would do.
3. Fix (5 min): Rewrite the load as delete-then-insert or upsert, and decide where the watermark is saved.
4. Log (3 min): List what the run log needs so you'd spot last night's failure in a minute.

The lab's numbers (84 of 90, and 152 after a bad retry) make a good worked example.

Discussion

- Why must the watermark be saved after the load?
- When would you choose upsert over delete-then-insert?
- Which failures should never be retried?

Check yourself

- Write the two SQL statements of an idempotent daily load.

Try it this week
Think of a job you repeat, like backing up your phone's photos. What happens if it runs twice, or stops halfway? Redesign it so a rerun is always safe.

Worksheet

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Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

1 **Which load is idempotent?**

◯ Delete the day's rows, then insert them ◯ Insert the day's rows on every run

◯ Insert, then remove duplicates by hand next week

2 **Put the steps of a nightly incremental load in order.**

☐ Save the new watermark and log the run

☐ Load: delete the day's rows, then insert

☐ Transform: clean, type and count

☐ Extract only the rows newer than it

☐ Read the watermark: the last time loaded

3 **The transform step. register.csv was typed by hand: some statuses are " p" or "P ", and one is "?". Clean each status with strip() and upper(), count the P's per class, set aside anything that isn't P or A, and print: 5A 4, 5B 3, 6A 5, then aside 1.**

```
import csv
present, aside = {}, 0
with open("register.csv") as f:
    for row in csv.DictReader(f):
        s = row["status"]
        if s == "P":
            present[row["class"]] = present.get(row["class"], 0) + 1
for c in sorted(present):
    print(c, present[c])
print("aside", aside)
```

Write your program:

4 **Last night's load failed after writing two of Monday's classes into daily. Make the load idempotent: before inserting today's rows, delete the Monday rows already in daily. The last line shows the totals per day: Fri 83 and Mon 84.**

```
INSERT INTO daily SELECT * FROM today;
SELECT day, SUM(present) FROM daily GROUP BY day ORDER BY day;
```

Write your program:

5 **Put the lines of an incremental load in order, so a failed load never loses rows.**

Number the lines in order (1, 2, 3…). Cross out any line that doesn't belong.

- [ ] `save_watermark(max(r["time"] for r in new))`
- [ ] `new = [r for r in rows if r["time"] > watermark]`
- [ ] `load(new)`
- [ ] `new = rows`
- [ ] `watermark = read_watermark()`

✎ **Think of a job you or your family repeat on a schedule (a backup, a bill, a shopping list). What happens if it runs twice, or stops halfway?**